ChatGPT Quick Start Guide

Plugins and skills

Prepare your GPT workflows for plugins

Custom GPT retirement is scheduled for December 11, 2026. Some Enterprise workspaces have an approved February 11, 2027 deferral. Follow your account or campus notice.

What moves	What needs attention	Your move
Published GPT instructions become a skill. Reference files and supported connected apps can move with the plugin.	Custom actions and sharing settings need review or rebuilding. Existing conversations remain accessible.	When available, open My GPTs > Migrate to plugin. Test familiar requests in the same workspace before switching.

For affected Enterprise workspaces, October 26 is the planned end of new GPT creation. Dates and access depend on workspace notices.

A skill handles a task. A plugin bundles a workflow.

	Custom GPT	Skill	Plugin
Purpose	A separate chatbot	Reusable task instructions	Skills, files and connected capabilities
Tools	Apps or custom actions	Uses tools available to the task	May include connected apps
Sharing	Existing GPT permissions	Account and workspace controls	Share intentionally; apps authorize separately

Build a skill the third time you repeat yourself

Make a skill	Make a plugin	Install one
You repeat a focused task, such as a weekly update or a document review.	A workflow needs connected services or a bundle your team can reuse.	Search the Plugins directory before building a tool that already exists.

1. Name one repeated task and its required result.
2. Use Skill Creator where available. Describe the goal, steps and output format.
3. Test with de-identified examples and refine the instructions.
4. Share where your workspace permits. Name a maintainer and provide example prompts.

Start small: policy-template checks, meeting notes to actions, clearer help articles or standard orientation slides.

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Models, effort and scheduled tasks

Match the model to the work

Narrow and repeated	Judgment across sources	Consequential decisions
Try GPT-6 Luna at Low for sorting, extraction or a task with a clear right answer.	Use GPT-6.1 Sol at Low or Medium for reports, reconciling documents and multistep work. Use the lowest effort that passes your check.	Increase effort when needed and add human review. Keep scope explicit. Consult your campus policy and the current Model Value Map.

Model availability and controls vary by account, surface and campus settings. October Chat releases differ from the versions used in Work and Codex.

Start low. Raise effort after a failed check.

Low / Light	Medium	High and above
Quick, well-scoped tasks.	More reconciliation or judgment.	Harder problems when a lower setting is insufficient.

- Menu labels vary. The API lists low, medium, high, xhigh and max; options depend on the model.
- Higher effort usually takes more time and usage. State the scope and ask for a verification step.
- API output-token reference prices: GPT-6.1 Sol $10 and GPT-6 Luna $0.50 per one million output tokens. Input and other usage also cost money. This is not total task cost.

For current task-specific recommendations, open the Model Value Map and its public guidance. Stay within your account's allowed models.

Let ChatGPT show up on a schedule

Monday	Wednesday	Friday
Open items and deadlines.	Find stale documents in an approved shared folder.	Draft a weekly update for review.

1. Open Scheduled when available, or describe the task and when it should run.
2. Choose a one-time or recurring schedule. Supported connected apps may offer event triggers.
3. Review the account, sources, instructions and permissions before relying on a run.
4. Check results and paused tasks in Scheduled. Codex automations are managed separately.

Computer-bound tasks need that device available. Cloud tasks have different requirements. If a task's model retires, update it before the next run.

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Tools, sharing and useful habits

Start with the work you already do

Documents and email	Research and study	Design
Google Drive, Gmail or Outlook: find an approved document, summarize a thread or draft a reply.	Consensus or Quizlet, where available: explore research or build practice flashcards. Check sources and accuracy.	Canva, where available: turn an outline into an event flyer. Review the result before sharing.

Also check Calendar, SharePoint, Slack, Teams and Notion. Availability varies. Use approved campus services and de-identified examples; follow your student-data policy.

Test privately. Share on purpose.

1. Open Plugins or the app directory shown in your account. Review the tool and its capabilities.
2. Select Install plugin when shown, then connect required apps using the intended account.
3. Start a chat and mention the installed tool where supported.
4. For your own plugin, test first, add example prompts and name a maintainer. Review sharing permissions; workspace publication is a separate permission.

Installing a plugin does not grant access to files or bypass your provider's permissions. Recipients may need to install it and connect their own apps.

Eight habits that make AI more useful

- State the setup: name the task, tools and desired result.
- Use phases when helpful; avoid a model switch that costs more than finishing.
- Invite one challenge if your request is unclear.
- Keep a project handoff: done, next and unresolved.
- Save recurring preferences through the tools your account supports.
- Verify saves and facts. Search before creating; read before editing.
- Check connected tools before a browser. Respect account and authentication boundaries.
- When a tool is missing, ask the assistant to inspect available capabilities.

Choose the surface for the result

Chat	Work	Codex
Questions, quick drafts and explanations.	Multistep jobs that produce a finished artifact.	Code, tests and repositories.

Quick win: connect an approved document service, find five recent documents and ask for a one-line summary of each. Start with one habit, then add the next.

Try these next

- [ ] Find the model and effort controls
- [ ] Mention an installed plugin in a chat
- [ ] Set one scheduled task and check its result
- [ ] Ask your campus admin what tools and data are allowed
- [ ] Run one multistep task in Work
- [ ] Create one focused skill with Skill Creator
- [ ] Try Record & Replay if available in your account
- [ ] Review your custom GPT migration notice and plan a tested replacement

Sources: GPT retirement and migration · Plugins and connected apps · Skills in ChatGPT · Scheduled tasks · Model specifications and API prices · October Chat model release · Current model guidance